

Malcolm X & Gloria Richardson: The women in Malcolm's kitchen cabinet

I want to dedicate this Malcolm X talk to the late Cheryl Y. Greene who helped edit the interviews for Malcolm X: Make It Plain and directed some of the research team for Manning Marable's Malcolm X research project.

This is an important passage from Malcolm X as he explained the program of the Organization for Afro-American Unity:

I've seen black musicians when they'd be jamming...that black musician, he picks up his horn and starts blowing some sounds that he never thought of before. He improvises, he creates, it comes from within. It's his soul, it's that soul music. It's the only area on the American scene where the black man has been free to create. And he has mastered it. He has shown that he can come up with something if given intellectual independence. He can come up with a new philosophy. He can come up with a philosophy that nobody has heard of yet. He can invent a society, a social system, an economic system, a political system, that is different from anything that exists or has ever existed anywhere on this earth. He will improvise; he'll bring it from within himself. And this is what you and I want... You and I want to create an organization that will give us so much power we can sit down and do as we please. Once we sit down and think as we please, speak as we please, and do as we please, we will show people what pleases us. And what pleases us won't always please them. So you've got to get some power before you can be yourself. Do you understand that? You've got to get some power before you can be yourself. Once you get power and you be yourself, why, you're gone, you've got it and gone. You create a new society, and make some heaven right here on this earth. (Woodard, Nation, 92)

Malcolm X, *By Any Means Necessary*

That passage is a window into Malcolm X's thinking in the organizing tradition. Just as many great Jazz artists—for instance, Dizzy Gillespie, Miles Davis and John Coltrane-- assembled new musicians in search of new music, Malcolm X recruited the best minds and young lions in the Black Revolt to design new strategy and tactics.

Malcolm X turned to a number of women who were formative in his thinking, including not only his mother and his wife, but also his sister Ella Collins in Boston; his mentor in the Harlem organizing tradition-- Vicki Garvin; Sarah Muhammad; Ruby Dee; Juanita Poitier; Mae Mallory; Abbey Lincoln, Rosa Guy and Maya Angelou; Alice Windom; Shirley Graham Du Bois; Rosa Parks; Claudia Jones; Yuri Kochiyama and Sonia Sanchez; and most importantly for this discussion, Gloria Richardson.

In these brief remarks I will concentrate on a few women who were formative in the making of Malcolm X and the Black Revolution. Malcolm X's mother Louisa or Louise Langdon Norton Little (1897-1991) was a Caribbean intellectual largely responsible for planting the imaginative seeds of Pan-Africanism that flowered into Malcolm X's life of learning. Erik McDuffie and I penned an article in the Biography journal that provides some of those details.

Betty Shabazz complemented Malcolm X's Grassroots intellectual development with her college education. If you look at the Schomburg Collection for the Malcolm X-Betty Shabazz library, then you will see the extensive and global study of history, slavery, abolitionism and Africa they shared.

Malcolm X's elder sister, Ella Collins, was supportive in a number of ways, including her prison correspondence where the youthful Malcolm explains that he was writing a book and that he had thrown away a few draft manuscripts because he required a better library for his research.

Malcolm X turned to Vicki Garvin at several points in his political life between the 1940s and 1964; and their ongoing conversations about self-emancipation, the organizing tradition in the Jim Crow North and comparative revolution lasted for more than two decades. Their last meeting was in 1964 at the Cairo summit of the fledgling Organization of African Unity (OAU) in Egypt: Vicki was on her way to meet Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai in the Chinese Revolution; and Malcolm X was meeting Mohammad Babu of the 1964 Zanzibar Revolution. Babu wanted to apply some lessons from the Chinese Revolution to the African Revolution.

Early in his ministry and organizing, Malcolm X turned to Sarah Muhammad who ran the Nation of Islam in the 1940s when the national male leadership was in prison for draft resistance.

In New York, Malcolm X turned to Ruby Dee; in turn Ruby Dee turned to Malcolm X for a solution to the health problem of drug addiction that plagued one of her relatives. And, Juanita Poitier organized the united front meetings at the Westchester home of Ruby Dee and Ossie Davis to bring Malcolm X and King together in the people's struggle.

In New York, Malcolm X also engaged in frequent political conversations with Mae Mallory in the public housing projects from the time in the 1950s when she joined the Harlem Nine in a court case against New York's educational apartheid. And, in that case, Malcolm X developed a friendship with her attorney Paul Zuber. By 1962 Malcolm X and Paul Zuber were working together on the desegregation of schools in Englewood, New Jersey. (Parenthetically: The daughter of one of those Englewood leaders developed into Imarisha in the leadership of the Bronx chapter of the Congress of African People. She says those meetings were in her living room.) But, Malcolm followed Mae Mallory as she joined Mabel and Robert Williams in the self-defense resistance in North Carolina and as she joined the United Nations protest of the murder of Patrice Lumumba in the Congo. Mae developed a reputation for two-fisted leadership. When she was attacked by the police at the United Nations, she made sure they were sorry that they put their hands on her!

Malcolm X also turned to the trio of leaders of the historic United Nations Riot of 1961: Jazz artist and actress, Abbey Lincoln; novelist, Rosa Guy; and the revolutionary artist Maya Angelou; they were at the helm of CAWAH or the Cultural Association of Women of African Heritage. Those women were responsible for rekindling the fire of Afro-American Nationalism that eventually turned into Black Power.

When Malcolm X was preparing his new politics he turned to Maya Angelou, Vicki Garvin and Alice Windom in 1964 who were sharing a bungalow in Ghana next door to W.E.B. Du Bois and Shirley Graham Du Bois. That trio was responsible for widening Malcolm X's international network because they had intimate connections with the Chinese, Algerian and Cuban diplomats as well as the leaders of the African liberation movements from Egypt to South Africa.

Vicki Garvin used connections provided by W.E.B. Du Bois to set up the Chinese state dinner during Malcolm's stay in Ghana. By the end of that trip, Malcolm X asked Maya Angelou to join him in Harlem to help guide his new organizations.

In Detroit, Malcolm X reached out to Mrs. Rosa Parks. It turns out that Rosa Parks adored Martin Luther King Jr; however, she did not go along with non-violence to the exclusion of self-protection. And, she loved Malcolm X's articulation of self-defense: to make friends with those who make friends with us; but to struggle with those who struggle with us. We used the picture of Rosa Parks holding the Malcolm X "By Any Means Necessary" poster on the cover of *Want to Start a Revolution? Radical Women in the Black Freedom Struggle*.

In Detroit, Malcolm X also met Gloria Richardson at the Grassroots Leadership Conference. He thought so much of Gloria Richardson at the helm of the Cambridge Movement in Maryland that she served as the paradigm for the new Grassroots leadership direction he proposed for the Black Revolt. The research suggests that when Malcolm X edited the original tape of the speech, he had the passage on Elijah Muhammad deleted to leave the emphasis on his direction toward the Gloria Richardson mass organizing in Cambridge. By 1964 Malcolm X and Gloria Richardson joined with Dick Gregory, Jesse Gray and a number of other leaders to establish the new group, ACT.

Thus, Malcolm X had assembled a number of women with cutting edge thinking in his strategic circles to design new programs, strategy and tactics for the Black Revolt. If we really want to know where Malcolm X was headed, then we must center that ensemble of women in the rethinking the story of Malcolm X in the last years. One indication of that direction is the link between Gloria Richardson, Malcolm X and Rap Brown. Gloria Richardson and Rap Brown were both at the 1967 National Black Power Conference right after the July Newark Rebellion. And, when Gloria Richardson asked Rap to help out the Cambridge struggle, Rap left the Black Power Conference. And, the rest in history....